District, and the moving force behind the experiment in cooperative peace-keeping: 'Who would not accept a policeman who is ready to help? I would, if I were a citizen.' With a woman's home-making instincts Bedi has set about putting her house in order, with a zeal that brooks no barriers. 'The beat constable has started thinking that the beat is his home. Just as his home has to be kept clean, so has his beat to be kept clean,' said Bedi.

Behind the zeal is a conviction that any social scientist will share – that combating crime and keeping the peace is an activity which involves the entire community, and the police can only be effective so long as they enjoy the support and cooperation of the community. By making public relations the bedrock of peace-keeping and law enforcement, Bedi has scored where strong-arm methods have failed. But support is slowly gathering. Says P. S. Bhinder, the embattled Commissioner of Delhi Police: 'We have always felt that fighting crime is not just a police effort, but also a public effort. Nowhere in the world are criminals fought by law alone.'

Public support seems to be one reliable factor in this move. Bedi put it this way: 'We have found that if the police take one step forward, the public responds by taking five steps forward.' But given the politicization of the police, given the paralysing wage structure of the policemen and the rot within the law enforcement system, that one crucial step which could transform the police from a goon force into a peace force might just be insurmountable.

(*India Today*, 1–15 June 1981)

Kiran Bedi relates an interesting anecdote regarding these beat boxes. 'The lieutenant governor of Delhi (S. L. Khurana), in a meeting with the commissioner of police and the various district commissioners, asked us separately as to the number of beat boxes we had put up in our districts. One said five, another seven and so on. I told him I had 165. So he asked the commissioner of police, P. S. Bhinder, why the other districts could not have as many. Mr Bhinder told him that if he were provided the finances he would be able to ask them to do so. The lieutenant governor then asked me how I had managed to get the finances and I told him that it was all through community effort. Mr Bhinder apparently never forgave me for that. He thought I had upstaged him. I had no intention to do so.'

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In a concerted effort to prevent crime, a ready reckoner of the criminals of West Delhi was published with the names of more than 3500 men and women (in an alphabetical order) having a criminal record since 1970. This 266-page manual, giving the criminals' past records, the area in which they lived as well as the *modus operandi* of their crimes, was distributed to all the nine police stations of Kiran's district to enable the duty officers to immediately check the antecedents of the criminals being brought in. The net result was a drastic fall in the crime rate.

The concept of a ready reckoner of criminals was carried forward during her tenure later as DIG (Range) in Mizoram (see Chapter 12 for details). However, this concept now evolved into a system of participative policing. Local leaders were given these lists so that people would be able to identify the criminals and help variously in detecting or rehabilitating such people. And this is how it was used.

CRIMINALS UNDER THE THUMB

The West District police has compiled a ready reference of criminals for use by police stations